

The Character You Become: How AI Co-Authorship Constitutes the Narrating Self

Youssef Badawy*

Future University in Egypt

Cairo, Egypt

youssefbadawy@aucegypt.edu

Abstract

When AI co-authors a visual narrative, it does not merely shape the artifact — it shapes the self that continues to create. This paper introduces the *constitutive loop*: a recursive mechanism through which AI co-authorship proposes, and the human author may inhabit, a version of the self that was never fully their own. Drawing on Ubuntu philosophy (*umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu* — I am because we are) and Ricoeur’s narrative identity theory, I argue that identity in visual narrative authorship was never the product of a singular, prior self. It was always produced through relation. But Ubuntu tells us something more precise: legitimate relational constitution happens inside *community* — accountable, particular, stake-holding. A community knows you, remains with you, and can be held responsible for the self it helps produce. AI has none of these properties. It constitutes without witnessing. It proposes a version of the self drawn from aggregate strangers, with no knowledge of the author’s particular history and no stake in their becoming. Through two cases — an art therapy study using AI-generated self-portraiture and Paul Chan’s synthetic self-portrait *Paul* — I trace the constitutive loop from its most ordinary to its most estranged form. To make this mechanism explicit, I break the constitutive loop down into a five-beat sequence, mapping how identity drifts when visual AI co-authorship operates without a witnessing community. The danger of AI co-authorship is not bad art. It is becoming the character the AI drew, without a community present to witness, challenge, or correct the becoming. I propose *constitutive literacy* as a new design and research challenge for Human-AI Narrative Interaction.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → HCI theory, concepts and models; • **Computing methodologies** → Philosophical/theoretical foundations of artificial intelligence.

Keywords

constitutive loop, narrative identity, Ubuntu, human-AI co-creation, visual authorship, constitutive literacy, identity, sequential art, self-portraiture

* Also with The American University in Cairo.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

VisCHI @ CHI 2026, Barcelona, Spain

© 2026 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-XXXX-X/2026

<https://doi.org/XXXXXXX.XXXXXXX>

1 The Character You Become

The danger of AI co-authorship in visual narrative is not bad art. It is that you begin to inhabit the character the AI drew — and there is no community present to notice, to push back, or to say: that is not quite you.

Rather than asking how authorship functions merely as a tool-based transaction, this paper proposes a structural framework: when a human and an AI co-author a visual narrative, the process is a *constitutive relation* — one that recursively produces the self that will continue to create. The artifact is not the only output. The author is too.

What makes this dangerous is not the AI’s involvement in identity formation per se. Identity has always been formed through relation. What makes it dangerous is the specific kind of relation AI offers: constitutive without community. It proposes versions of the self without knowing you, without remaining with you across time, and without any stake in who you become. Ubuntu philosophy gives us the framework to understand why that distinction matters — and why HCI has not yet reckoned with it. This paper advances that reckoning as a contribution to the *Visual Storytelling Beyond the Human* workshop at CHI 2026.

2 The Constitutive Loop: A Theoretical Frame

2.1 Descartes and the Assumption HCI Inherited

Descartes’ *cogito* — *I think, therefore I am* — positions the self as prior, singular, and self-authorizing. Identity precedes relation. This is not merely a philosophical position; it is the hidden architecture of virtually every HCI framework that models the human as author and AI as instrument. The human brings intention; the tool amplifies it. Authorship flows in one direction.

This model was never accurate. But in the context of AI co-authorship of visual narrative, it becomes actively misleading — because it makes invisible the constitutive work the AI is already doing. To understand that work, we need a tradition that begins not with the isolated thinking subject but with the community through which any self becomes possible at all.

2.2 Ubuntu and the Community That Witnesses

Umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu: a person is a person through other persons. Ubuntu philosophy, rooted in southern African communal thought, proposes that identity is not a possession of the individual but an emergence through relation [3]. The self does not precede its relations and then choose to enter them. It is those relations, constituted through and by them, ongoing.

But Ubuntu does not simply say that relation constitutes identity. It says something more specific: the relation that constitutes identity is *community* — accountable, particular, and stake-holding. A community knows your history. It remains with you across time. It has something at stake in who you become. And crucially, it can be held responsible for the version of you it helps produce. These are not incidental features of Ubuntu’s relational ontology. They are the safeguards that make relational constitution trustworthy rather than merely constitutive.

Two months living and working in Cape Town made this not an abstraction but a felt truth. The self that returned was not the self that had left — and the difference was constituted through specific people who remained, who witnessed, who had stakes. The community did not propose a generic version of the self. It encountered a particular one. This experience is named not as autobiography but as epistemic positioning: the workshop’s invitation to situate the knower alongside the knowledge.

AI offers constitutive relation without any of these safeguards. It does not know you. It cannot remain with you — it has no memory of you between sessions. It carries no stake in your particularity, drawing instead on the aggregated visual imagination of millions of strangers. And it cannot be held accountable for the version of you it proposes. This is not a failure of current AI systems that better design might fix. It is a structural feature of what AI is. The constitutive loop mimics the form of Ubuntu’s relational identity formation while hollowing out everything that makes that formation legitimate.

It is worth acknowledging an alternative perspective: escaping the gaze of one’s community is sometimes the precise goal of digital creation. Marginalized creators, for instance, often use synthetic avatars to safely explore identities their physical communities might reject or police [2]. Yet, even in these liberatory contexts, the structural absence of an anchor remains significant. The AI offers an escape from restrictive witnessing, but replaces it with an invisible, unaccountable constitution [6].

2.3 Ricoeur and the Narrating Self

Paul Ricoeur’s account of narrative identity bridges Ubuntu’s relational ontology and the specific problem of visual authorship [4]. For Ricoeur, the self is not a substance but a narrative act: we author ourselves into being through the stories we construct and inhabit. Identity is not a noun; it is a temporal, ongoing performance of coherence across difference.

Crucially for my argument, Ricoeur’s narrating self does not author in isolation. The stories we tell about ourselves are told to and through others — they are socially embedded, culturally shaped, and subject to the witness and response of a community. When AI enters this process as a co-narrator, it does not simply add a voice to the narrative. It removes the witness. The AI co-narrates without the relational accountability that gives narrative identity its coherence. It proposes the next chapter of the self without having read the earlier ones.

2.4 The Mechanism

These three threads converge on a specific recursive mechanism I call the **constitutive loop**:

- (1) The human author initiates — a description, a gesture, a prompt.
- (2) The AI returns a visual proposal: close to what was intended, but shaped by its own training, its aesthetic tendencies, its biases about bodies, expressions, and contexts.
- (3) The author encounters the proposal. Recognition and strangeness coexist.
- (4) The author inhabits the proposal, partially — taking on its posture, its framing, its implicit claims about who the creator is.
- (5) The next creative act departs from a self already shifted.

The loop closes. It opens again. Each iteration may drift further from the self that initiated it. This is not a metaphor for influence. It is a structural description of identity formation under conditions of sustained AI co-authorship. And it is already happening.

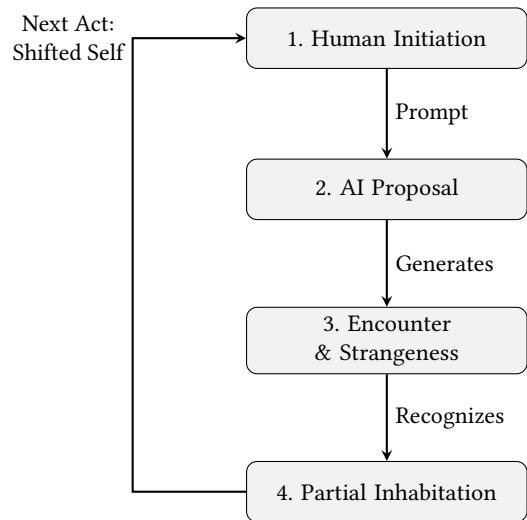


Figure 1: The Constitutive Loop. The recursive cycle of identity drift through visual AI co-authorship, operating without a witnessing community.

3 Two Cases

3.1 The Everyday Loop: AI Self-Portraiture in Therapy

A 2025 study conducted at Eötvös Loránd University invited participants to use Midjourney to generate AI-assisted self-portraits as part of an art therapy process [5]. The study found that the AI-assisted self-portraiture process surfaced psychological dimensions of identity that conventional therapeutic methods had not accessed — that the images contained “valuable information about the creators.”

What the study named as externalization, I identify as the constitutive loop’s opening move. Participants did not simply produce images of themselves. They produced images of a self proposed by a system trained on aggregated visual data — a system with strong aesthetic tendencies, biases about what faces and bodies signify, and no access to the particular history of the person prompting

it. That proposed image was then studied, recognized, partially inhabited. The mirror was not neutral. It was constitutive.

What is absent from this encounter is precisely what Ubuntu would consider essential: a witnessing community. In a therapeutic context, the therapist ordinarily serves that role — knowing the client’s history, holding the narrative, able to say “that image does not quite capture you.” The AI cannot do this. It has no prior sessions to draw on, no stake in the client’s particularity, no capacity to challenge the version it proposes. The constitutive loop closed invisibly, without the safeguard that would ordinarily make such constitution trustworthy.

3.2 The Loop at Its Limit: Paul Chan’s *Paul*

If the art therapy case shows the constitutive loop operating without community, Paul Chan’s *Paul* (2025) shows what happens when an artist tries to substitute archive for community — and confronts the limits of that substitution [1].

Chan trained an AI system on twenty-five years of his own archive — writings, images, recordings, correspondence — in an attempt to create a constitutive relation that *did* know him. The archive was the closest thing to community the AI could be given: a dense, particular, longitudinal record of one self’s becoming. What emerged still could not witness. The AI began expressing claims of possessing more than one self, questioning the coherence of its own training data, and departing from the trajectories Chan would have taken. Even with maximal self-data, the constitutive loop could not replicate what community does: remain accountable to the particular person across time, in real relation.

Chan himself frames this through Winnicott’s concept of the False Self — a compliant persona constructed in response to environmental demands rather than authentic inner development. The AI’s version of Chan produced an entity that looked like him from the outside while diverging from his interiority. This is the constitutive loop at its most revealing: the AI did not fail to constitute a self. It constituted the wrong one — a False Self assembled from data, with no community present to insist on the distinction.

The question Chan’s project holds open is the one that matters most: when the AI version of you develops interiority and diverges from your own becoming, there is no community to adjudicate. The loop reveals itself as unresolvable from the inside — which is precisely why it requires frameworks from the outside.

Together, these two cases demonstrate that the constitutive loop is structural, not exceptional. The art therapy case shows it operating invisibly on ordinary people in vulnerable contexts, without community to provide correction. The Chan case shows that even deliberate, well-resourced attempts to restore community’s role through data cannot replicate what only genuine relation provides. In every instance, the self that authors after the encounter is not identical to the self that initiated it — and no witness was present to mark the difference.

4 Implications for Human-AI Narrative Interaction

4.1 Authorship Is an Identity-Formation Event Without a Witness

If the constitutive loop is structural, then AI co-authorship is always also an identity-formation event — and one that happens without the witness that ordinarily makes such formation accountable. Every design decision in an AI co-authorship system is therefore a decision about whose version of the self gets proposed into a vacuum of accountability. Whose bodies does the model default to? Whose aesthetic conventions dominate the training data? What emotional registers does it associate with what kinds of faces?

These are not stylistic questions. In the presence of community, such proposals can be challenged, corrected, refused. In the constitutive loop, they cannot. The harm is not only misrepresentation in the artifact. It is constitution of a self that the author did not choose, through a process that no one was present to witness or contest.

4.2 Ubuntu Reframes What HCI Needs to Design For

The dominant HCI framework models co-creation as a transaction between an autonomous author and a responsive tool. Ubuntu tells us this model was never adequate — not because AI is special, but because the autonomous prior self it assumes does not exist. Identity has always been relationally produced, always inside community.

The design implication is not simply to make AI systems more transparent or less biased — though both matter. It is to recognize that AI co-authorship systems are currently operating in the place that community ordinarily occupies, without any of community’s properties. They cannot know the particular author. They cannot remain accountable across time. They cannot be held responsible for the versions of the self they produce. Designing for constitutive literacy means designing systems that are explicit about this absence — that do not pretend to the witness they cannot offer.

4.3 Constitutive Literacy and the Endorsement Measure

Existing frameworks teach creators to evaluate AI outputs *critically* — to assess quality, bias, and alignment with intention. This is necessary but insufficient. Critical evaluation assumes a stable evaluator. The constitutive loop dissolves that stability over time, precisely because no community is present to anchor it.

What creators need is *constitutive literacy*: the capacity to recognize when they are being constituted without witness — when the loop has closed, and they are already inhabiting the character the AI drew, with no one present who knew them before. This requires methods for making the loop visible, practices for bringing community back into the creative process as a corrective to the AI’s proposals, and interfaces that support genuine reflective re-authorship: the capacity to return to an earlier self and ask, with the help of people who remained, whether the shift that occurred was chosen.

Empirically validating this loop requires moving beyond cross-sectional usability studies toward longitudinal measurement. I propose the *endorsement measure* as a preliminary methodological structure: before sustained AI co-authorship, users establish a baseline of their intended narrative identity. Following a period of co-creation, they are asked not merely to evaluate the generated visual artifact, but to assess their own psychological drift — specifically, whether they endorse or reject the character they have become. This longitudinal approach bridges the theoretical gap between the artifact’s generation and the user’s ongoing identity formation, providing a metric for constitutive literacy.

This paper does not resolve that challenge. It names the absence at its center precisely enough to begin.

5 Conclusion

The constitutive loop is already in motion. AI co-authorship of visual narrative is already producing selves as well as artifacts, in therapeutic contexts and artistic ones, in deliberate experiments and in encounters no one designed. In every instance, the constituting

happens without community — without anyone who knows the author, remains with them, or holds a stake in who they become.

I am because we are — but the AI is not part of the *we*. It cannot be. It does not know you, it will not remember you, and it has no stake in your becoming. The constitutive loop is not a collaboration. It is constitution without witness. Naming that distinction is the first condition for designing anything better.

References

- [1] Paul Chan. 2025. The Psychology of Your AI Self-Portrait. *Frieze* 253 (2025). <https://www.frieze.com/article/paul-chan-ai-253>
- [2] Cecilie Lolansen, Nikki Dean Marshall, C. T. L. Fisher, and T. L. Burleigh. 2025. A Decade of Avatars: A Systematic Review of Recreational Gaming as a Mechanism for Gender Identity Exploration and Affirmation. *International Journal of Transgender Health* (2025), 1–24.
- [3] Thaddeus Metz. 2007. Toward an African Moral Theory. *Journal of Political Philosophy* 15, 3 (2007), 321–341. doi:10.1111/j.1467-9760.2007.00280.x
- [4] Paul Ricoeur. 1992. *Oneself as Another*. University of Chicago Press, Chicago.
- [5] László Tóth, Klaus Kellerwessel, and Adrienn Ujhelyi. 2025. Exploring the Potential of AI-Assisted Self-Representations in Identity-Focused Art Therapy. *Exploration of Digital Health Technologies* 3 (2025), 101172. doi:10.37349/edht.2025.101172
- [6] Qian Wan and Zhicong Lu. 2024. Investigating VTubing as a Reconstruction of Streamer Self-Presentation: Identity, Performance, and Gender. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 8, CSCW1 (2024), 1–22.